

Existential angst



Arguably the first ‘existentialist’ philosopher (although the term was not adopted until the 20th century), Søren Kierkegaard reacted against Hegel’s idea of man as simply a part of a historical process. Instead, he felt that we are free to make the ethical choices that shape our lives, rather than accept the value system passed down to us by society or religion. In his more subjective approach to philosophy, Kierkegaard examined what it is like to be human, and in particular the effect our freedom to make decisions has on our lives. It is the responsibility of each individual, he believed, to give life meaning, and live it to the full. But the realization that we have absolute

freedom in our choices is a daunting experience – it creates a feeling of anxiety, what we would now call ‘existential angst’. Kierkegaard describes this ‘dizziness of freedom’ as similar to the vertiginous feelings we have when standing on the edge of a cliff; we fear falling, but also that we may be overcome by a sudden impulse to throw ourselves off, since nothing prevents us from making that choice.